reached me. My brother-in-law and mentor Jenab Ahmed Jal aludin, was no more. For a couple of minutes, I was immobilized, I could not think, could not feel anything. When I could focus on my surroundings once more and attempted to participate in the work, I found myself talking incoherently —and then I realised that, with Jal aluddin, a part of me had passed away too. A vision of my childhood reappeared before me—evening walks around the Rameswaram temple, shining sand and dancing tides in the moonlight, stars looking down from an unlit sky on a new moon night, Jal aluddin showing me the horizon sinking into the sea, arranging money for my books, and seeing me off at Santa Cruz airport. I felt that I had been thrown into a whirlpool of time and space. My father, by now more than a hundred years old, pal bearer for his son-in-law, who had been half his age; the bereft soul of my sister Zohara, her wounds from the loss of her four-year-old son stil raw—these images came before my eyes in a blur, too terrible for me to comprehend. I leaned on the assembly jig, composed myself and left a few instructions with Dr S Srinivasan, Deputy Project Director, to carry on with the work in my absence.